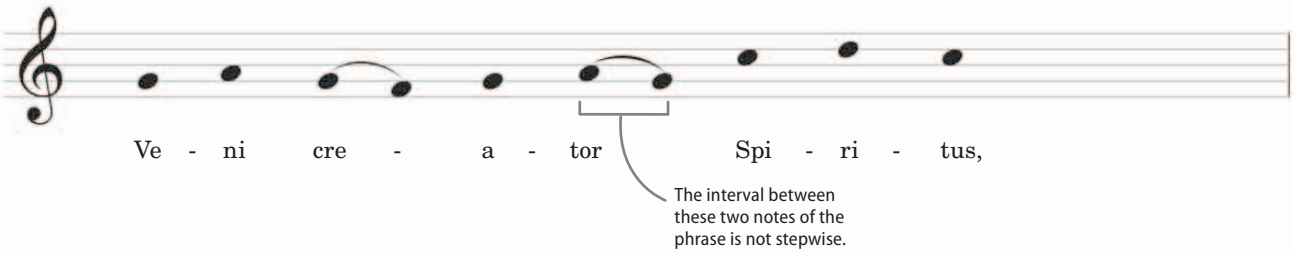
What is a monody?

A monody—also known as monophony—is a melody with no other notes sounding at the same time. The relationship between these notes is called melodic harmony. In European societies, monodies have been used for many centuries in church music, where they are called plainsong or plainchant. There are simple intervals between each note, so that they may be sung by people together without musical training.

▽ **"Veni Creator Spiritus"**
"Come, Creator Spirit" is one of the oldest plainchants, from the 8th century. All but one of the intervals is stepwise—next to its neighbor—to sound at the same time simple and beautiful.

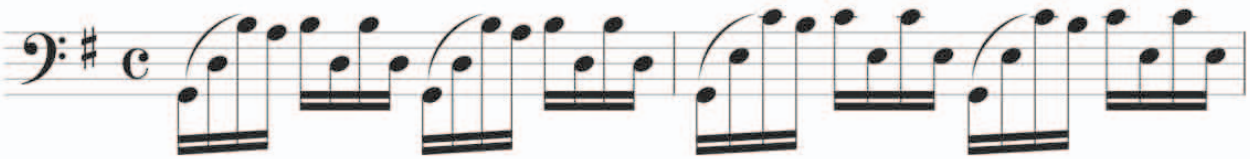


LOOKING CLOSER

The harmony of a melody

Writing music for solo instruments, such as the clarinet or trumpet, that cannot play chords, or string instruments for which a long passage of chords is impractical, presents its own challenges, but harmony can be implied and imagined even when only one note is heard at a time. The music may return often to the tonic to reassert the key signature, as shown in the example below.

▽ **Bach's *Cello Suite 1***
Bach wrote suites and sonatas for the violin and cello, which use the rapid passage of notes across the string to sound like chords. In the opening of his First *Cello Suite,* he creates both a melody and a harmony that is rooted in G major.



REAL WORLD

Harmony of the spheres

In around 500 BCE, the Greek scientist Pythagoras proposed that the movement of the stars and planets was governed by the same mathematical proportions as the intervals between musical notes. This meant that each planet had its own sound, and together they made a "harmony of the spheres." The idea of harmony as a natural phenomenon still influences musicians and composers. Pythagoras discovered that the distance between notes could be expressed in terms of mathematical ratios. He saw these ratios as a reflection of the structure of the universe.